

defined methodology and ownership, the idea couldn't be sold. One aspect of Linux is that there are just too many distros. Just when you're getting used to one, another one comes and steals some of its thunder. It makes you want to try something new to not be left behind in the Linux world, which ensures that the average user never really experiences the comfort levels that one achieves when they've been using a product for a long time. A second problem is that when something starts off as essentially free, more creative ways need to be found to fund the project. Donations are usually the way to go, but with most rich people getting that way because of shrewd business acumen, just giving away money to a project is a lot hard to do. Plus, there're millions of starving kids in Africa who need the money for food, not computers!

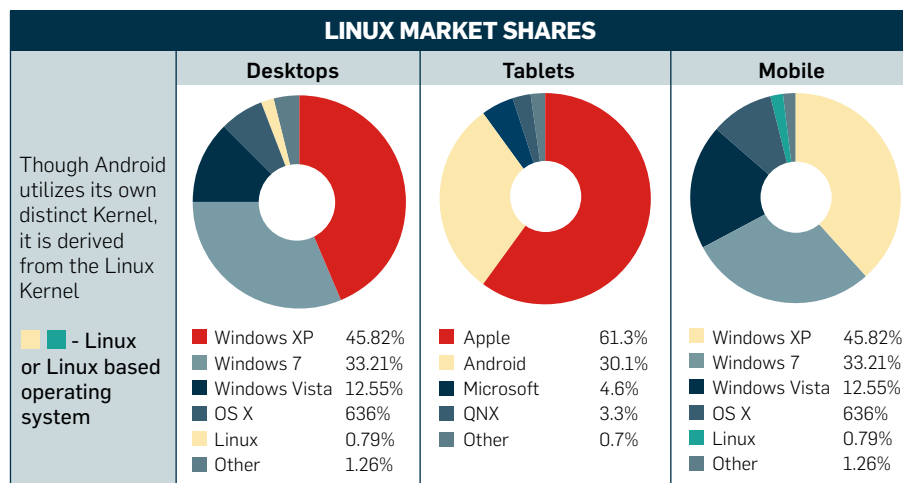
Years ago, when the movement was starting to gather momentum, Netscape becoming open source was called "a shot that was heard round the world", and sadly, current iterations of OSS seem to be following the same path.

The torch bearer

Linux has been the poster-boy for the Open Source movement for many years now, but it seems to be losing steam quickly. That is, if you count only the desktop versions, and no derivatives. Android, for instance is a derivative that holds a lot of promise, and is currently the most talked about Open Source project out there. One would expect that this relationship would be mutually beneficial, and it was indeed supposed to be. However, we now see that Android, with each new release is getting farther and farther away from its native Linux base, and the developments that the Android community is trying to give back are hardly being implemented into the actual development of the kernel. That's the problem with being a torch bearer, at the start of a competition, you get your 15 minutes of fame, but in the end you're not much more than a has-been athlete, doomed to sit in the stands watching the real stars compete for the laurels...

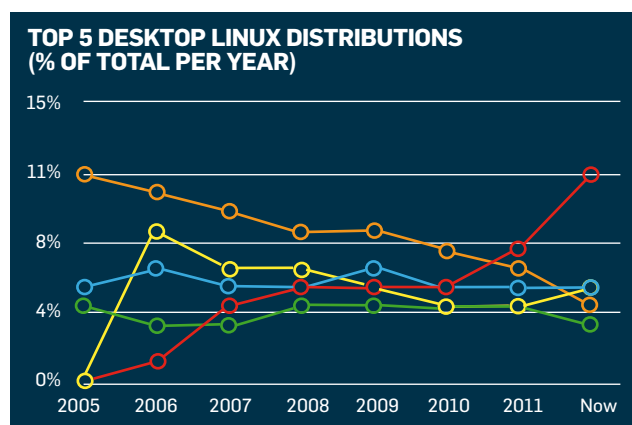
Now what?

While almost everybody with a basic knowledge of computers is aware of the existence of Linux, and Open Source in general, only a handful have gotten any

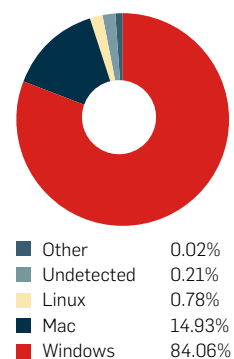


Sources: Android, Statcounter, Nielsen & Zdnet

Data by MBAOnline.com



Data source: DistroWatch's Page Hit Ranking (Nov. 23, 2011). www.pingdom.com



Average adoption till date according to Statowl

BROOKS' LAW

Software development is said to hinge on Brooks' Law, which states that as the number of programmers rises linearly, the amount of work done will scale up by the same proportion, but the number of bugs rises by a square function, i.e., if number of people 'X' on a project rises, then the assignment completes X times faster, but the number of bugs rises by X^2 .

INTRA DISTRO COMPETITION

The constant chopping and changing of distros, with freakishly frequent updates, and competition amongst each other (while intended as a good thing) means that the world does not see a single 'torchbearer', and because a lot of these are not mutually inter-compatible, proper open-source support becomes a pain in the ass.

real exposure, let alone become regular users. Plus, we're an impatient bunch these days. We can't wait for a web page to load, let alone spend time figuring stuff out.

Thanks to Apple and Google, we need everything now, this instant, and it should work like a dream, right out of the box. What prayer does an OS like Linux have in such a world of impatience? Can a bunch of code hackers really get together and do something about the human condition? We already suspect that many companies still support Linux for brownie points. Besides, the Linux community may be small, but is certainly very vocal, and no one wants to clutter up the Internet with negativity about their company. Of course, we're talking Linux here, not Open Source in general... Thanks to projects such as Android, the OSS mantra will live on, for a very long time indeed. We certainly hope so, as avid OSS enthusiasts. However, given the stats we've seen around us over the past few years, it's impossible to ignore the elephant in the corner of the funeral home. Although it is one of the most famous parts of a movement we're all eternally grateful for, and will support for a long as we are able, we do have to face facts. Linux is dying, and we're the ones who are killing it.